Pluralism and syncretism are deep historical traits of the Ocean and they have been strengthened by liberalism as well. If we stop and think about it, the Indian Ocean is the most populous English-speaking lake in the world, larger than the Atlantic Ocean. The colonial era undoubtedly did much damage to this ocean community. But it also left behind institutions, practices and values that are naturally supportive of international norms and rule of law. A combination of history – both ancient and more recent – provide the foundation today to build a more contemporary region with its own personality.

But despite its legacy and its aspirations, the reality is that the unity of the Indian Ocean is not self-evident. The reasons for that are complex and worthy of a debate by themselves. In part, it was the effect of the lateral fragmentation of the region by external powers. Colonial domination created artificial firewalls through their administrative jurisdictions that diluted centuries of natural movements and contacts. Their salience also saw an accentuation in the divisions between the ocean and its littoral societies, with a shrinking of local maritime practices and capabilities.

As these inherent traditions of seafaring diminished due to European presence, we were left with a less active visualization of this vast global commons. The greatest disruption was the impact on the ocean culture by the fate of India. The reduction of its influence under colonial rule was aggravated by its partition. Both in reach and importance, the fulcrum of the ocean stood significantly diminished. Not just that, the emergence of modern nation states after decolonization again put such a strong emphasis on territoriality that it further reduced the salience of regional and trans-regional cooperation and flows. The Indian Ocean was thus seen as less intrinsically coherent than, say, the Atlantic or the Pacific. Even its smaller constituents, like the Bay of Bengal or the Arabian Sea, are not deemed to have a culture akin to the Mediterranean, the Caribbean or the North Sea. Rebuilding that will not be easy especially if there are powerful forces with contrary interests.

The Indian Ocean, like many other regions, must therefore find more solutions within. A key step in that direction is to create the connectivity that promotes a clearer personality to emerge. It is obviously unrealistic to